WrestleCraft: Review and Master Plan

Oct 21, 2026 · @Bill

The verdict

WrestleCraft has the best idea in its genre and is not yet the best game in it. The live show run from the gorilla position, with people who remember every call, is something no booking sim on Steam does as well, and the paper diorama broadcast is the most charming presentation the genre has had. But today the game can be coasted for two years without getting fired, its numbers contradict each other, and the first hour is chores. I would grade it **B- today, with a clear road to A**.

Question	Short answer	Confidence
Is it fun?	The core loop is fun for a wrestling fan. Today it lacks stakes, so the fun leaks out after a few weeks. Fix balance and it holds.	Medium. Based on the 30-run balance probe and the play-through in the earlier review, plus a read of the code and plans; I did not play it again for this doc.
Is it commercially viable?	Yes, as a niche indie. A realistic first year is roughly 8,000 to 20,000 copies at $24.99. It is not a living for a team, but it can pay back and build a franchise.	Medium. Built from competitors' Steam review counts and a rule of thumb, not market data.
Is it better than the others?	On presentation and the live show, yes. On depth of data, modding and balance, Total Extreme Wrestling is still ahead, and Pro Wrestling Sim plays cleaner today.	High on the comparison, medium on how players will weigh it.

The biggest danger is not a competitor. It is scope. In one day the project approved 14 new feature sections, 13 long-game features, a corkboard, a podcast and a visual storytelling plan, about 1,400 lines of plans in PR #6, on top of a game whose basics are unfinished.

Bill's call to pause new features until balance is fixed is the right one, and the plan below keeps to it.

The game today (version 0.88)

The engine is A-grade and the experience on top of it is C-grade. This section builds on the earlier game review, which built the game, ran all 50 headless tests and 30 two-year balance runs, and played it at 1920x1080.

Is it fun?

The fun is real, and it lives in three places:

- **The gorilla position.** Calls arrive because something true happened on the night: a rival at the curtain, the owner wanting a favourite to win, a hot crowd begging for a title change. Each answer costs something with people who remember it. This is the moment players will clip and stream.
- **A locker room with memory.** Backstage reads like real catering-table politics, and choices stick through the relationship matrix. Bill's approved plans (word travels, the hallway, come back changed) all deepen exactly this.
- **Writing.** Commentary, the dirt sheet and the Net are varied, funny and true to the game state.

Three things drain that fun today:

1. **No stakes.** In 30 two-year runs using only Suggest a card and the safe answer to every call, nobody was fired, and about 25 bookers were handed the company. A management game you cannot lose is a toy. Phase 1, already under way, fixes this.
2. **Mixed signals.** Shows grade B and A while popularity falls 9 to 13 points and cash falls $42M to $78M. The player cannot tell which number matters, so good play does not feel good.
3. **A slow, admin-heavy start.** The first desk asks for two commentators and a sponsor review, the owner's letter is in the retired terminal style, and the game's own suggested card grades C with "Lost the crowd". The first impression is failure and paperwork.

Two smaller drains: too many voices compete for attention each week (desk, tasks, inbox, writers, road agent, feed), and audio is synthesised music and blips with no crowd, bell or pops. For a game built around a live show, sound is half of it.

What is strong under the hood

- 102 engine files that feed each other through people, memory and money, all seeded and repeatable.
- 50 headless tests and about 40 browser tests, all passing except one tablet check that is no longer a target.
- A clean split: the engine owns the state and the screens never write to it. That makes balance work safe.

What is weak

- **Readability of code.** 1.3 MB of dense ES5, with some functions rewritten in later files up to six times. It works, but each new feature costs more than the last.
- **Steam readiness.** The Electron wrapper launches, but Steam calls have never run against the Steam client, there is no Windows installer or icon, one save slot, a save failure is never reported, and there is no settings screen for resolution or audio.
- **Visual churn.** The art direction changed five times between 6 and 19 October. Each change restarts "move every page to the new look".

What "everything we just added" is

PR #6 (branch `claude/director-plan`) adds 17 plan files and about 1,400 lines to TASKS.md and `docs/plans/`. It holds no code. The plans are good: each has headless-test-first steps, ties into existing systems, and records Bill's exact words. The problem is volume. The 14 newly approved sections (TASKS 0aa to 0an) hold 69 numbered steps, before the 13 long-game features, the creator suite and the 16 older roadmap items still open. That is more than a year of work at the current pace, which is why the plan below draws a launch line.

Is it commercially viable?

Yes, as a focused niche game, and the timing is good: the genre leader is not on Steam, but at least four new booking sims are arriving there in 2026. The market is small and loyal. Success depends on launching with a polished first hour, a demo and a clear hook, not on more features.

The competition on Steam

Game	Price	Released	Steam reviews	What it means for WrestleCraft
Total Extreme Wrestling IX	$34.95	Aug 2024	Not on Steam; sold direct with a free trial	The deepest sim, 20+ years of fans and mods. Its absence from Steam leaves the store's shelf open.
Pro Wrestling Sim	$19.99	Mar 2021	669, 97% positive	The closest comparison: text-based, clean, loved. Shows the ceiling for a pure booking sim on Steam.
Wrestling Empire	$19.99	Jul 2021	3,164, 94% positive	An action game with a booking career. Proves wrestling fans buy charming, low-budget indies.
Believr Pro Wrestling	not listed	Jan 2026, early access	27, mostly positive	New indie promotion sim; a weak start shows how hard visibility is.
Booker Blitz	not yet	Early access planned Nov 2026	none	**The direct threat.** Its store page leads with a "Gorilla Position" for live match control: run-ins, changed finishes, cut or extended matches. It has a demo, Steam Cloud and achievements. Most of its wrestlers, belts and logos are AI-generated.
Territory Titans: Booking Wars	not yet	Coming soon	none	Territory-era management sim; overlaps the territory map idea.

Game	Price	Released	Steam reviews	What it means for WrestleCraft
Pro Wrestling: The Ascent	not yet	Q4 2026	none	Text career sim; overlaps the planned wrestler career mode.

Outside the indie shelf, WWE 2K's MyGM mode gives casual fans a light, licensed booking game every year inside a full-price wrestling game. It sets expectations for presentation, not depth (from memory, not checked for this doc).

How big could it be?

A common rule of thumb puts Steam sales at about 30 to 60 copies per review. On that rule, Pro Wrestling Sim has sold roughly 20,000 to 40,000 copies over five years and Wrestling Empire roughly 100,000 to 190,000. These are estimates, not reported figures.

Case	First-year copies	Gross at $24.99	After Steam's 30%, refunds and regional pricing (about 55% kept)	What it takes
Low	2,000 to 4,000	$50K to $100K	$28K to $55K	Launch with today's balance and first hour; no demo.
Base	8,000 to 20,000	$200K to $500K	$110K to $275K	Phases 1 to 5 done, a demo in Steam Next Fest, 7,000+ wishlists at launch.
High	40,000+	$1M+	$550K+	Base, plus streamers pick up the live show and the parody world travels on social media.

The base case pays back a small team and funds updates. It is not a studio-sized hit, and nothing in the genre suggests one.

Price

$24.99, with a 10 to 15% launch discount. That sits above the $19.99 text sims, because the broadcast and art earn it, and under TEW's $34.95, because TEW has twenty years of depth. Offer a free demo of Booker Mode's first month: TEW, Booker Blitz and Pro Wrestling Sim's fans all expect to try first.

Risks, most serious first

1. **Scope.** Well over 100 open plan steps against one developer. Every month spent on new systems is a month of competitors on the shelf and no wishlists building.
2. **Booker Blitz claims the hook first.** It launches into early access next month with "Gorilla Position" as its headline. WrestleCraft must market the difference: calls caused by the people and the night, consequences people remember, and a broadcast you watch, not a menu.
3. **The parody world as the Steam default.** This is Bill's decision and the plan keeps it. Since 20 October the parody rosters wear their real people's colours and signature gear, which is closer to likeness than changed names. Get a written opinion from an entertainment lawyer on the actual build before the store page goes up, because a takedown after launch would cost the launch.
4. **No stakes at launch.** Players review the first two hours. If coasting still works, reviews will say "no challenge" and the score will sink below the 90% the genre's hits hold.
5. **Steam technical gaps.** No Windows installer, Steam calls never run, one save slot, silent save failures. Any one of these produces refunds.
6. **Audio.** A live show with no crowd noise will read as unfinished in a trailer.
7. **Screen sizes.** Not a risk: Bill confirmed the game is laid out at 1080p and will scale up to all main modern resolutions. Phase 3 tests text stays sharp at each.

Is it better than the others?

Not yet overall, but it is the only one that could be the best of both worlds: TEW's living world with a show you actually watch. It already wins on presentation and the live show, and loses on balance, clarity and modding history. Once phases 1 to 3 below are done, I would expect it to beat Pro Wrestling Sim and Booker Blitz outright and to be the better game than TEW for anyone who is not a spreadsheet purist.

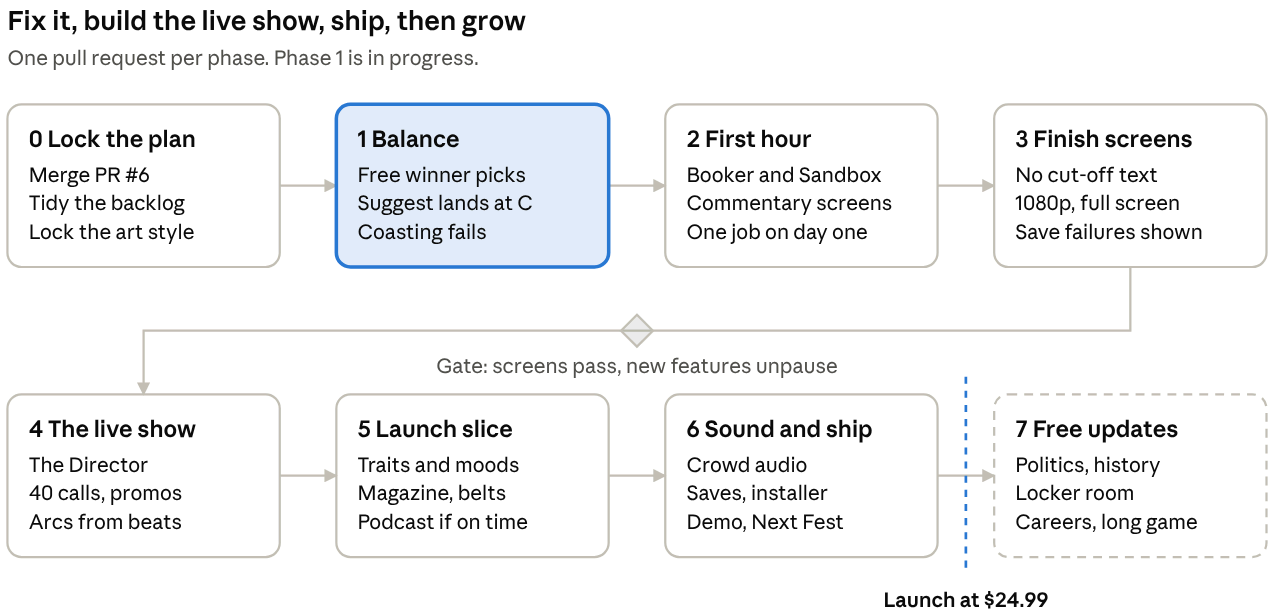
Area	WrestleCraft today	TEW IX	Pro Wrestling Sim	Booker Blitz (from its store page)
Watching the show	**Best.** Paper diorama broadcast with entrances, near falls and a live fan feed	Text results	Text results	Text with voiced announcers
Live calls during the show	**Best.** Caused by the night and the people, remembered afterwards	None	None	Strong: audibles, run-ins, finishes changed
People and memory	**Best.** Relationship matrix, backstage people, memory of your calls	Strong, with inner circles and backstage politics	Moderate	Unknown
Depth of the world	Strong: nine company models, rival bookers, a living world	**Best**: huge database, real-world calendar, 20 years of tuning	Moderate	Unknown
Challenge and balance	Weak: cannot be lost today	Strong	Strong	Unknown
Clarity and first hour	Weak: chores, mixed signals, cut-off text	Weak: famously steep	**Best**: simple and readable	Keyboard-first
Modding and worlds	Good: World Editor, Create a Wrestler, Workshop planned but untested	**Best**: decades of community worlds	Good	JSON datapacks and a data editor
Art and sound	Art **best** and hand-made; sound weakest of all	Minimal	Minimal	AI-generated art, neon theme
On Steam	Coming	No	Yes	Next month, early access

Two marketing angles fall out of this table. First, "the show you watch, the calls you make, the people who remember". Second, "made by hand": with Booker Blitz built on AI art, a hand-made paper look is a point of pride with this audience.

The plan going forward

Seven phases, one pull request each, merged by Bill or Ryan. New features stay paused until phases 1 to 3 are done, as Bill decided. Launch comes after phase 6. Phase 7 is free updates after launch, which keep the game visible on Steam. Store-page and Steam technical work starts in parallel from phase 2, because wishlists take months to build.

This replaces the earlier roadmap and the A+ plan in the game review, and puts every plan in PR #6 in one order.



the road to launch · 8 phases, 1 gate, launch after phase 6

The top row fixes what exists; new features start only once its gate is passed. Everything right of the launch line ships as free updates.

Phase 0: lock the plan (days)

- Merge PR #6 as the plan of record. It holds only plans, so it changes nothing in play.
- Tidy the backlog: mark TASKS sections 3 to 9 done or cut, remove the duplicate 0v, 0w and 0x sections, retire IDEAS.md, and update `docs/design.md`, which still describes the DOS look and tablet modes.

- Lock the workbench art style. No more look changes before launch.

Phase 1: balance (in progress)

Started in the Game review and A+ plan thread. Free winner picks are already in.

- Picking the winner is free; booking power buys extras (protected finish, run-in, surprise, upset title change).
- Suggest a card lands around a C.
- Coasting fails within a year: one yearly owner goal (popularity target, cash floor, one story beat), and a tougher handover.
- Popularity follows good shows, or the game says why it does not.
- EWE stops losing about $1M a show.
- A balance test in the suite with targets per company model.
- All rights reserved licence file.

Gate: in the balance test, a Suggest-only booker is in danger by the end of year one, and a thoughtful one can win.

Phase 2: Booker Mode and the first hour

- The two modes: **Booker Mode** opens in the week of the grand show, one week before the business year ends, with the last booker's mess as the teaching tool (TASKS 0ac). **Sandbox Mode** is a free start with no mess. The wrestling year runs flagship to flagship.
- The world switch at the top right of the title screen, parody world as the default.
- Commentary: separate screens for play-by-play and colour, built to allow a third voice later.
- Seat the commentary team and skip sponsor admin in week one, so the first desk has one job.
- Restyle the owner's letter in the workbench look; a progress card during the 10-second start.
- A cap on interruptions: the top three matters a week, the rest resolve on their own.

Gate: a new player books and airs the grand show within 15 minutes, understands the yearly goal, and is not graded a failure for following the game's own advice.

Phase 3: finish the screens at 1080p

- An ellipsis and contrast check in the screen test, then zero cut-off text and no unreadable labels at 1920x1080. Drop tablet size from the tests.
- Use the full 1080p screen, as Bill asked, and scale it up to all main modern resolutions (1440p, 4K, ultrawide), checking text stays sharp at each.
- Roster bars that differ, with words, so a glance shows who is tired or unhappy.
- The bug list from the review: silent save failures first, then the sign-off card, the toast, the dirt-sheet byline, the storylines title, the camera clipping through the referee.
- Keep the longer broadcasts, as Bill decided.

Gate: the screen test passes with the new checks on every page. New features unpause here.

Phase 4: the live show, the core feature

This is what sells the game against Booker Blitz. Build in this order, because each step feeds the next.

1. The Director, steps 1 to 3 (TASKS 0aa): the tension reading, then it chooses the week's events.
2. Catching fire and tagging today's 13 calls (0ae steps 1 and 2), then the Director on the night (step 3).
3. Word travels (0ai). Small, and every call then ripples.
4. Promos written from everything going on (0ag), Bill's "main idea".
5. The hallway on the desk (0aj), in the promo voices.
6. Company arcs from beats (0ad), Bill's "key feature", steps 1 to 4 with the rival booker shape first.
7. The forty new calls (0ae step 4), a batch at a time; the Director's three styles and event sizes (0aa steps 4 and 5).

Gate: a show in a playtest produces at least one call a player wants to talk about, and arcs start from what happened rather than a menu.

Phase 5: people and the world, the launch slice

Only the pieces that make the launch better, or that screenshots and trailers need.

- Traits, wants and moods (0ah steps 1 to 3). Perk slots at 60 to 90 can follow after launch.

- The monthly magazine (0af steps 1 to 2, and the annual issue). Its covers are ready-made marketing images.
- Visual storytelling, first steps from the visual plan: champions carry their belts in every portrait, then the Power Ten board.
- The weekly podcast replacing the chat room (podcast plan), if Phase 4 lands on time; otherwise it is the first post-launch update.

Phase 6: sound and ship

- Audio: crowd beds that follow the crowd meter, entrance pops, the bell, near-fall roars.
- Saves for a PC game: named slots, visible save files, Steam Cloud, a clear error when a save fails.
- The Windows installer and icon; Steam achievements and Workshop calls run against the real Steam client.
- An options screen: window mode, text size, audio levels.
- The lawyer's written opinion on the parody world as built.
- Store page, trailer cut from the broadcast, a demo of Booker Mode's first month, Steam Next Fest. Start the store page as soon as phase 3 is done.

Gate: launch at $24.99 with a launch discount, with about 7,000 wishlists or more.

Phase 7: after launch, as free updates

Roughly in this order, one update every four to six weeks:

1. Backstage Politics (0ak) and They come back changed (0al).
2. Pre-history from real history, and ten simulated years for new companies (0ab), after the lawyer has seen the anchors.
3. Perk slots and signature perks (0ah steps 4 to 6); the rest of the magazine.
4. The locker room diorama (0am) and buildings that remember (0an).
5. The corkboard (TASKS 13); a three-person commentary booth.
6. Careers and the long game (TASKS 14): the owner's five-year vision and the path to the Hall first, since they are small and feed the yearly loop, then families, trends, world firsts, mission trees, rival owners and plans, coalitions, the territory map, and last the wrestler career mode and one life in wrestling.
7. Owner mode and the rest of the creator suite.

What stays cut: free agency week, power blocs and privileges, fast mode leftovers, pre-booking the week, picking the building, and the Steam Deck and tablet targets.

Decisions this plan follows, and what is still open

Every decision below was made by Bill on 21 October 2026 and is built into the phases above.

Topic	Decision	Phase
New features	Paused until balance, the first hour and the screens are fixed	1 to 3
Picking the winner	Free; booking power pays for extras	1
Suggest a card	Lands around a C	1
Licence	All rights reserved	1
Modes	Booker Mode starts at the grand show in the last week of the business year; Sandbox is a free start; years run flagship to flagship	2
Worlds	Both ship; parody is the Steam default; world switch top right of the title screen	2
Commentary	Separate screens for play-by-play and colour; three-person booths later	2, 7
Screens	Laid out at 1080p using the full screen, scaled up to all main modern resolutions; no Steam Deck or tablet	3
Broadcasts	Keep the longer broadcasts	3
Pull requests	One per phase, merged by Bill or Ryan	All
Rejected	Free agency week; power blocs and privileges	Cut

Open questions

- [ ] Does Ryan agree with this order, in particular moving the GM skill tree, which he queued after the arcs on 16 October, to after launch?
- [ ] Who is the entertainment lawyer, and when can they see the parody world as built?

- [ ] Is there a target launch window? It decides whether the podcast makes the launch slice.
- [ ] Should the store page and demo go up early to answer Booker Blitz's November early access, or wait for phase 4 so the demo shows the full live show?